Memorandum of Understanding

In Support of the Southern University LIFT Rural MBDA Business Center Proposal

This Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) is entered into by and between KDM and Southern University and A&M College, Baton Rouge campus (Southern University), collectively referred to as the Parties. This MOU documents the Parties' intent to collaborate in support of Southern University's application for and, if awarded, implementation of the LIFT Rural MBDA Business Center serving rural businesses across Louisiana.

Party	Representative / Role
KDM & Associates LLC	Keith Moore, Authorized Representative
Southern University and A&M College, Baton Rouge campus	Chancellor Pierre, Authorized Representative

1. Purpose

The purpose of this MOU is to establish a collaborative framework through which KDM & Associates LLC will support Southern University in developing, launching, and operating a rural business center focused on business formation, growth, capital readiness, procurement readiness, advanced manufacturing commercialization, digital literacy, cybersecurity readiness, and supply-chain development for rural Louisiana businesses.

The Parties intend for this MOU to demonstrate partner commitment for the MBDA Rural Business Center proposal and to describe the planned working relationship, subject to award, final institutional approvals, and any separate subaward, contract, or service agreement required by applicable federal and university policies.

2. Project Period

The anticipated project period is September 1, 2026 through August 31, 2029. The Parties may begin coordination before the project start date for planning purposes, provided that no costs are charged to the federal award before the authorized start date and no Party is obligated to incur costs unless a separate written agreement authorizes such costs.

3. KDM & Associates LLC Responsibilities

- Support program-management planning, implementation coordination, and performance reporting for the LIFT Rural MBDA Business Center.
- Provide or support an intake, customer-relationship, data-tracking, and reporting platform that helps the Center assess client needs, route clients to services, monitor progress, and report against MBDA performance measures.

- Assist rural businesses with procurement readiness, including federal contracting pathways, CMMC readiness, HUBZone and Opportunity Zone awareness, Mentor-Protege readiness, teaming, and prime-supplier preparation.
- Support advanced manufacturing and supply-chain development activities that connect rural businesses to opportunities in agriculture, energy, logistics, critical infrastructure, and Department of Defense or national-security-related supply chains.
- Assist with industry engagement and business matchmaking involving prime corporations, original equipment manufacturers, financial institutions, and other market-access partners as appropriate.
- Coordinate with Southern University staff and partners to document client services, training participation, referrals, outcomes, and evidence needed for grant performance reporting.

4. Southern University Responsibilities

- Serve as the lead applicant and, if awarded, the direct recipient responsible for fiscal, administrative, programmatic, and compliance oversight of the cooperative agreement.
- Provide leadership through the College of Business and coordinate institutional participation from the College of Sciences and Engineering, Southern University Law Center, the Small Business Development Center, the Agricultural Research and Extension Center, and other university units as appropriate.
- Provide access to appropriate university facilities, subject-matter expertise, entrepreneurship training capacity, and advanced manufacturing resources needed to support the Center's approved scope of work.
- Oversee compliance with federal award requirements, including procurement, subrecipient or contractor monitoring, reporting, records retention, conflicts of interest, allowable costs, and applicable requirements under 2 CFR Part 200.
- Coordinate final work plans, budgets, performance targets, reporting schedules, and partner roles with KDM and other project partners.

5. Shared Commitments

- Operate the Center as a merit-based, place-based rural business development initiative focused on eligible rural businesses and rural economic need.
- Avoid duplication of existing federal, state, and local services by coordinating referrals with MBDA, SBA, SBDC, APEX Accelerators, economic-development organizations, lenders, and other relevant partners.
- Maintain client confidentiality and protect business, financial, technical, cybersecurity, and personally identifiable information consistent with applicable law and institutional policy.
- Use data and evidence to evaluate performance, improve service delivery, and document progress toward core measures including clients served, businesses served, capital infusion, jobs supported, contracts, and revenue growth.
- Participate in regular coordination meetings and provide timely information needed for grant reporting, audits, and project review.

6. Governance and Points of Contact

The Parties will identify operational points of contact after award or upon execution of a related subaward or service agreement. The Parties anticipate regular project-management meetings during startup and periodic meetings thereafter to review outreach, service delivery, client outcomes, budget status, risks, and corrective actions.

7. Funding and Non-Binding Nature

This MOU expresses the Parties' good-faith intent to collaborate. It does not, by itself, obligate either Party to expend funds, transfer funds, hire personnel, or provide reimbursable services. Any exchange of funds, payment terms, deliverables, intellectual-property terms, data-security requirements, insurance requirements, or detailed scope of work will be governed by a separate written agreement approved by the authorized officials of both Parties.

8. Compliance

The Parties will conduct activities in accordance with applicable federal, state, and local laws; the terms and conditions of any MBDA award; Southern University's policies; and applicable federal grant requirements, including 2 CFR Part 200. The Parties will not use federal or matching funds for prohibited activities, including direct loans, grants, equity investments to businesses, construction, lobbying, or other unallowable costs.

9. Confidentiality, Data, and Records

Each Party will protect confidential information received from clients or the other Party. Records created under the project will be maintained in a manner that supports federal reporting, audit readiness, and client confidentiality. Any technology platform, database, or reporting tool used for project activities will be configured to support authorized access, secure data handling, and documentation of services and outcomes.

10. Intellectual Property and Publicity

Pre-existing intellectual property, curriculum, software, templates, data systems, or proprietary materials remain the property of the originating Party unless a separate written agreement states otherwise. Neither Party may use the other Party's name, marks, logos, or endorsements in public materials beyond the grant application and approved project communications without prior written approval.

11. Term, Amendment, and Termination

This MOU becomes effective on the date of the last signature and remains in effect through August 31, 2029 unless extended, replaced by a more specific agreement, or terminated earlier. Either Party may terminate this MOU upon thirty (30) days' written notice. Amendments must be in writing and signed by authorized representatives of both Parties.

12. Signatures

By signing below, the Parties confirm their intent to collaborate in support of the Southern University LIFT Rural MBDA Business Center proposal and, if funded, to work in good faith to implement the roles described in this MOU subject to final award terms and institutional approvals.

For KDM & Associates LLC

Signature: DocuSigned by: 754C68274E75476... _____

Name: Keith Moore

Title: Authorized Representative

Date: 6/29/2026 _____

For Southern University and A&M College

Signature: _____

Name: Chancellor Pierre

Title: Chancellor

Date: _____